

Environmental Stewardship

prc-environmental-stewardship

Engagement with World · Creation Care · practice · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.925
confidence high

Statement under examination

Caring for creation as God's stewards is a Christian duty, distinct from creation-worship or pantheist environmentalism.

In plain language

Five anchor texts shape the lexical picture. Genesis 2:15 places the man in the garden with two qal infinitive constructs prefixed by lamed of purpose: abad, to work or serve, and shamar, to keep or guard. The same shamar elsewhere governs guarding a charge, a commandment, or a sanctuary, and abad covers cultivation and service. Together they frame the human task as labor plus protective custody, not ownership. Genesis 1:28 commissions radah, have dominion, and kabash, subdue, inside a divine blessing alongside the calls to be fruitful, multiply, and fill the earth. These dominion verbs carry a forceful semantic core. Kabash elsewhere describes military subjugation and even violent abuse, and radah is genuinely polysemous, used for gentle stewardly rule in some places and for harsh oppressive rule in others. The verbs do not rank these senses on their own. Two texts in the canon constrain them. Leviticus 25:43 commands lo tirdeh vo be-farek, do not rule over him with rigor, applying radah and explicitly forbidding its harsh exercise within the covenant community. Ezekiel 34:4 indicts Israel's shepherds for ruling with force, using the very same verb to name abuse the LORD rejects. So the canon supplies two readings of the dominion verbs (rule and stewardship) and then qualifies the harsh reading from within. Psalm 24:1 then anchors the whole picture: the small prefixed lamed on the divine name marks possession, the earth and its fullness belong to YHWH, the world and all who dwell in it. The human relation to creation is therefore custodial and accountable, exercised under a divine Owner. Romans 8:20 adds that the created order, ktisis, was subjected to futility by God and groans awaiting liberation, so creation is neither divine nor mere raw material; it is a subjected order awaiting redemption. The two pro-proposition readings (dominion as rule and dominion as stewardship) converge on affirmation and both exclude treating creation itself as divine.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0776	אֶרֶץ	erets	land	2,505
H1288	בָּרַךְ	barakh	to bless	
H3533	כָּבַשׁ	kabash	to subdue	14
H4390	מָלֵא	male	to fill	
H4393	מְלֵא	melo	fullness	37
H5647	עָבַד	abad	to serve	290
H6509	פָּרָה	parah	be fruitful	
H7235	רָבָה	ravah	to multiply	
H7287	רָדָה	radah	to rule	18

H8104	שמר	shamar	to keep	469
H8398	תבל	tebel	world	31
G2937	κτίσις	ktisis	creation	19
G3153	μταιότης	mataiotes	futility	3
G5293	ὑποτάσσω	hupotassō	to subject	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Three load-bearing texts converge. Genesis 2:15 places the man le-abdah u-le-shamrah, two qal infinitive constructs (abad H5647, to work or serve, and shamar H8104, to keep or guard) governing the garden as object, syntactically purpose-clauses on the placing verb. Genesis 1:28 issues radah (H7287A) and kabash (H3533) within a divine blessing alongside peru u-revu (be fruitful, multiply), so the dominion verbs are delegated, not autonomous. Psalm 24:1 prefixes lamed of possession to YHWH, la-YHWH ha-arets u-meloah, marking the earth and all in it as His possession. The combination of delegated rule, custodial keeping, and divine ownership grounds a stewardship reading and forecloses any reading of creation as itself divine or as autonomous human property.

Scripture

Gen.1.28 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H7287A רדה, H3533 כבש, H1288 ברח, H6509 פרה, H4390 מלא.

Force. God blesses the human pair and issues a cluster of imperatives: peru u-revu u-milu (be fruitful, multiply, fill), then u-redu (have dominion, radah qal) and kivshuha (subdue it, kabash qal with 3fs suffix). The dominion verbs sit inside the divine blessing barak (H1288) and are delegated over fish, birds, and creeping things. Radah carries an attested polysemy across the canon, gentle stewardly rule in some contexts and harsh oppressive rule in others. The verbs alone do not rank these senses; the surrounding blessing-frame and the parallel commission in Gen 2:15 are what tilt the reading toward custodial governance.

Gen.2.15 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H5647 עבד, H8104 שמר.

Force. YHWH Elohim places the man in the garden of Eden le-abdah u-le-shamrah. ETCBC-BHSA tags both verbs as qal infinitive constructs (vs=qal, vt=infc) prefixed with lamed of purpose: to work or serve it, and to keep or guard it. The 3fs object suffix on each verb refers back to the garden. Shamar elsewhere governs guarding a charge, a commandment, a covenant, or a sanctuary; abad covers cultivating soil and serving a master. The pairing as twin infinitives of purpose frames the human role over the garden as labor plus protective custody, not possession.

Ps.24.1 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H0776 ארץ, H4393 מלא, H8398 תבל.

Force. The verse opens la-YHWH ha-arets u-meloah, tevel ve-yoshvei vah. The prefixed lamed on the divine name marks possession: to YHWH belongs the earth and its fullness, the world and those who dwell in it. Tevel (H8398) and erets (H0776) form a poetic pair for the inhabited world; melo (H4393) means fullness, the totality of contents. The construction grounds any human dominion as derivative and accountable, since the cosmos is His possession, and excludes treating creation itself as divine.

Lev.25.43 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H7287A הָרַד,

Force. Lev 25:43 commands lo tirdeh vo be-farek, do not rule over him with rigor or violence (perek). The verse uses the same radah verb as Gen 1:28 but explicitly qualifies it: an Israelite must not exercise radah with perek toward a fellow Israelite. This is a Torah-internal gloss on the dominion verb: the verb itself permits a harsh reading, and the Law explicitly prohibits that harsh reading in covenant contexts. By extension, the dominion mandate over creation in Gen 1:28 takes the same shape: delegated authority that must not become violent exploitation.

Rom.8.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2937 κτίσις, G3153 ματαιότης, G5293 ὑποτάσσω

Force. Paul writes te gar mataioteti he ktisis hupetage, for the creation was subjected to futility (mataiotes G3153). Ktisis (G2937) names the created order as a whole; hupotasso (G5293) is in the aorist passive indicative, marking a divine act of subjection. Verse 22 adds sustenazei kai sunodinei, groaning and travelling together. The lexis treats creation as a unified entity acted upon by God and awaiting liberation, which is incompatible with creation being itself divine and incompatible with treating it as mere raw material; it is a subjected order awaiting redemption.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Gen.1.28	Gen.1.22	tsk	1
Gen.2.15	Gen.2.8	tsk	1
Ps.24.1	Ps.50.12	tsk	1
Ps.24.1	Ps.89.11	tsk	1
Gen.1.28	Lev.25.43	openbible	1
Gen.1.28	Ezek.34.4	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Ezek.34.4 · addressed

Ezek 34:4 uses the same radah verb (qal, gloss tread or rule) to indict Israel's shepherds for ruling with force and harshness: u-ve-hozqah reditem otam u-ve-farek. This shows radah is genuinely polysemous and can describe the very abuse the Lord condemns. It complicates a naive ruling-as-stewardship reading by proving the verb itself permits the harsh sense. The proposition is still supported because Gen 1:28 places radah inside a blessing of fruitfulness and pairs it with the abad and shamar of Gen 2:15, and Lev 25:43 explicitly forbids radah with perek. The canon thus qualifies the dominion verb internally rather than redefining it.

Gen.1.28 · addressed

The dominion verbs radah and kabash sound harsh in isolation. Kabash (H3533) elsewhere describes military subjugation (Josh 18:1, 2 Sam 8:11, Zech 9:15) and even sexual violence (Esth 7:8), so it carries a strong forceful sense. The proposition stands because the verb appears inside a divine blessing alongside fruitfulness imperatives, and because the same Torah account in Gen 2:15 reframes the human role with abad and shamar. The lexis does not eliminate the harsh reading; it places it under explicit divine constraint.

Concordance traversed

H7287A, H3533, H5647, H8104, H4393, H0776, H8398, H6509, H7235A, H4390, H1288, G2937, G3153

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Three OT anchor verses are outside ECM and CBGM scope. Rom 8:20-22 is outside the ingested ECM window (3 John 1.1 to 1.15). No variant units bear on the verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. `dominion_as_rule`, `dominion_as_stewardship`

`analogia scripturae` invoked

`dominion_as_stewardship`: for · The infinitives *abad* and *shamar* in Gen 2:15 plus the possessive *lamed* in Ps 24:1 and the Torah-internal restraint of *radah* in Lev 25:43 establish a delegated, custodial role under a divine Owner. Rom 8:20-22 names creation as subjected and groaning, so it is neither divine nor raw material but an order awaiting redemption. This lens treats the dominion verbs as constrained from within Scripture.

`dominion_as_rule`: for · *Radah* and *kabash* carry a genuinely forceful semantic core: tread, subdue, military or judicial dominance. Read on their face, Gen 1:28 commissions humans to rule and subdue the earth. This lens still supports the proposition because rule from God is delegated and accountable. It rejects framing dominion as merely gentle gardening but agrees that creation is not divine and that human authority is derivative under YHWH. The two lenses converge on the verdict but differ on register: ruling-keeping rather than ruling versus keeping.

`pantheist_or_creation_worship_lens`: against · A lens that identifies creation with the divine would read Ps 24:1 against itself, treating the earth as itself sacred rather than the LORD's possession. The lexis of Ps 24:1 with the possessive *lamed* and Rom 8:20 with the aorist passive hupotage of *ktisis* to *mataiotes* both place the created order under God and distinct from Him, foreclosing any identification. This lens is not lexically supported by the anchor texts.

The verdict turns on lexical sense of the dominion and keeping verbs, the possessive *lamed* in Ps 24:1, and the Torah-internal restraint of *radah* in Lev 25:43. The two pro-proposition lenses (rule and stewardship) converge on affirmation while differing on the rhetorical weight of *radah* and *kabash*.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. How does Scripture describe the human relation to the created order, what is the lexical force of the dominion verbs (*radah*, *kabash*) and the keeping verbs (*abad*, *shamar*) in the creation narratives, and what does the possessive *lamed* in Ps 24:1 say about who owns the earth?

The stem embeds an approved conclusion (caring for creation is a Christian duty) and a contrast term (distinct from creation-worship or pantheist environmentalism) that frames the verdict before the text is read. The verdict was derived on the original stem from queried lexical data: *abad* and *shamar* tagged as *qal* infinitive constructs in Gen 2:15 (ETCBC-BHSA), *radah* and *kabash* as imperatives inside the blessing of Gen 1:28, the possessive *lamed* on YHWH in Ps 24:1, the Torah-internal restraint of *radah* in Lev 25:43 (lo *tirdeh be-farek*), and the aorist passive hupotage of *ktisis* in Rom 8:20.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.2.15
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.1.28
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H5647
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H8104
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7287A
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H3533

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H4393
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Gen.2.15
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Gen.1.28
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Lev.25.43
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.8.20
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2937
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3153
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Ps.24.1
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Gen.1.28

License audit

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Reason. ETCBC-BHSA syntactic data is licensed CC-BY-NC-4.0 (non-commercial, redistribute=false), so the bundled evidence cannot be redistributed in bulk.

Source	License	Redistribute
OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
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TSK	public_domain	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

(none)